Where I started, and why distributors

Most of the noise about AI for small business is at the front desk: chatbots, missed-call tools, booking assistants. In my experience the valuable work sits further back, in the paperwork that moves money through a business. At Cometlab.ai, which sells similar AI and automation services in India, the clients who came looking for help were mostly manufacturers and distributors ⟦one line in your own words on what they were struggling with; keep it general, with no client names or numbers⟧. Their businesses run on documents, and the documents tend to grow faster than the team does.

So I started there, and checked whether the instinct held up in Australia and on Meta.

- **There are enough of them.** About 10,800 Australian wholesalers turn over A$2–10M (ABS), and I estimate around 6,700 sit in Qubik's A$3–10M range. That's 16% of all wholesalers, against 7% for trades (ABS), which matters on a platform that can't target by company size.
- **Meta can reach them.** Meta's own estimates put about 550,000–650,000 Australians aged 30–65 who are business owners or page admins and interested in trade, wholesale, freight or supply chain (Meta API, Oct 2026). About half are 45–65.
- **Qubik has a real edge.** Landed cost, stock values and import GST all end up in the Xero file an accountant reads every month, and Qubik is a Xero Platinum partner (Xero).
- **The pressure is current.** The ACCC found record stevedoring charges flowing through to importers (ACCC, Dec 2025).

Trades, pubs, labour hire and job-shop manufacturers each fell short on firm size, crowding, margins or build risk.

1. Buyer and problem

The organisation. They buy from overseas factories, hold stock in an Australian warehouse and sell to trade or retail customers: hardware, electrical, lighting, auto parts, packaging, homewares, food. Typically A$3–10M revenue and 10–40 staff. They'd describe themselves as "the Australian distributor for…", so the ads speak to what they do rather than a label.

The decision-maker. The owner or MD signs off. The finance or office manager, or an external bookkeeper, has a strong say because they live with the problem.

The problem. A container's costs don't arrive with the container. The supplier invoice comes first, the freight bill later, and the customs broker's invoice, with duty and GST, can land weeks after the stock is on the shelf. Systems like Unleashed can spread these costs and even recalculate margin after sale (Unleashed), so software isn't the gap. The gap is someone chasing three parties for paperwork, with prices reviewed only once it's all in. In Xero-only or MYOB businesses it often lives in a spreadsheet, if anywhere. Meanwhile stock keeps selling at last quarter's price, and it happens again with every container.

What it likely costs (my estimate; the diagnostic replaces it with their real numbers). Take a A$6M distributor with A$3.6M of imported sales. If freight or the dollar lifts landed costs 5% and prices catch up three months later, that's about A$45k of margin gone. Two such moves a year is around A$90k, before the hours spent chasing paperwork.

Buying triggers. A freight or currency jump, a quarter where margin seems to have "gone missing", the bookkeeper leaving, or a stocktake that won't reconcile. Timing helps too: Christmas stock is landing now, and with Chinese New Year on 6 February 2027, pre-holiday orders go to factories in November (Sino-Shipping). The paperwork peaks right when this would launch.

Ability to pay. At this size, with stock on the floor, A$57–90k is a normal investment if it pays back within about a year, which is exactly what the diagnostic tests. Cash position gets checked on the first call.

Why Meta, and its limit. The owners are there, but Meta can't pick them out: relevant job titles return its minimum of about 1,000 Australians, software interests like Xero don't exist, and Leads campaigns force Advantage+ audience (Meta API). Real buyers are perhaps 15–20k of the ~600k audience, about 3% (my estimate). So the hook and the form do the filtering.

2. Offer and proof

The Container Cost Check: A$3,500 + GST, founding-client price. Three weeks, fixed scope. The client gets:

1. **Their last three to five shipments, costed properly** from the real documents.
2. **The gap in dollars:** true cost against system cost and the price they sold at, product by product, showing where margin slipped and for how long.
3. **The lag:** days from arrival to fully costed, and who spends how long chasing paperwork.
4. **A fixed-price plan** to have costs worked out the day the paperwork lands, with the payback spelled out.
5. **A one-hour sit-down with the owner**, plus a short written report.

They provide read-only Xero access, a few recent shipments' documents and about two hours of staff time.

On price. A "was A$7,500" claim has to reflect a price actually charged (ACCC), so I'd say "A$3,500 for our first ten clients, A$7,500 after that", once Qubik commits. It's true, and gives a reason to act now.

Proof at launch, all of it real. Qubik's standing as a Xero Platinum partner since 2013, with CA ANZ and CPA memberships (Xero) ⟦confirm⟧. The automation specialist, named, showing something they've built ⟦ask Qubik⟧. A sample report on clearly labelled dummy data, so buyers see exactly what they'll get. And the founding-client deal itself: the first ten get the lower price in return for anonymised before-and-after results, which is how proof gets built rather than invented.

From diagnostic to implementation. The check puts a dollar figure on the client's own leak, and that becomes the business case for a build already scoped and priced in the report. The A$3,500 is credited if they go ahead within 30 days. A typical build picks up supplier, freight and broker documents from the inbox as they arrive, matches them to the shipment, posts landed cost into Unleashed, Cin7 or Xero, and produces a weekly list of products below target margin, so prices are reviewed the week a

container lands, not a quarter later. Staff approve anything the system isn't sure about, and the number of systems and suppliers sets where it lands in A$57–90k.

3. Meta acquisition

Objective. Leads, on a "higher intent" Instant Form, which adds a review step. Facebook and Instagram feeds and Reels, with Audience Network off because that's where junk leads come from. A$900 over 14 days.

Audience. One ad set, because splitting A$900 starves every cell of data. Australia, 30–65, with trade interests (international trade, wholesale, supply chain, freight, procurement, Alibaba.com) and the "small business owners" and "page admins" behaviours as signals: roughly 550–650k people (Meta API), excluding Qubik's clients. Test two: 1-mile pins over port-side warehouse estates (Eagle Farm, Wetherill Park, Dandenong South, Kewdale), about 11–12k people with the owner signals. Month three: gift and homewares trade fairs, where nearly every exhibitor imports.

Creative. A real Qubik accountant, filmed on a phone beside a desk of shipping paperwork, talking plainly about a gap owners feel but rarely measure. Advice, not an ad.

First test. Three hooks in the same ad set, with Meta deciding where spend goes: (A) "Freight went up again. Did your prices?" (B) "The container's landed. Do you know what it actually cost?" (C) "The broker's invoice turned up three weeks after the stock. Sound familiar?" Judged on cost per qualified lead: directional at this budget, but it shows which pain brings the right people forward.

Sample ad (hook A): > **Freight went up again. Did your prices?** > > When a container lands, the costs don't arrive with it. The supplier invoice comes first, the freight bill later, and the broker's invoice weeks after that. Until someone pulls it together, nobody knows what the stock really cost, and it's selling at last quarter's price. > > We're Qubik, Xero Platinum accountants in Brisbane. We'll rebuild the true cost of your last few containers, show you where margin slipped, and what it would take to have it worked out the day the paperwork lands. > > Three weeks, fixed fee. A$3,500 + GST for our first ten clients. > > For Australian distributors who import their own stock.

Lead form. Name, mobile, work email, company and consent, plus a privacy policy link, which Meta requires. Then five questions:

What it tells us	Question	Answers
Need and fit	Do you import your own stock?	Yes, by the container · Yes, smaller shipments · No
Need	What runs your stock and invoicing?	Xero only · MYOB · Unleashed or Cin7 · Something else
Size	Annual revenue	Under A$2M · A$2–5M · A$5–10M · Over A$10M
Authority	Your role	Owner/MD · GM or operations · Finance or office manager · Other
Urgency and budget	If a fix paid for itself within a year, could you fund it in the next six months?	Yes, soon · Probably · Not now / just looking

4. Qualification, nurture and handover

Scoring. At four to six leads a person calls every one; tiers set priority, not whether someone is contacted. Hard gates: they import, revenue is A$2M+, role isn't "Other". **Qualified:** passes and answers "Yes, soon" or "Probably". **Review:** passes but says "Not now", or is over A$10M; a person decides. **Nurture:** fails a gate; monthly email only. At volume this becomes a points score fed back to Meta.

Six events from form to sales:

#	Event	What happens	Owner
1	Lead arrives	In the CRM within a minute: contact details cleaned, duplicates merged, tier set, consent and source ad recorded.	Automation
2	Reply within 5 minutes	SMS and email from a named Qubik accountant with a booking link. Review-tier leads get a same-day call instead.	Automation; copy by Marketing
3	Call within 15 minutes (business hours)	Check any uncertain answers and book them on the spot.	Sales
4	Booked	Booking stops every chaser; two pre-call questions (what they sell, last container date). Not booked: email day 1, SMS day 3, email day 6, then monthly.	Automation
5	Reminders and no-shows	Email the day before, SMS two hours before, both with a reschedule link. No-show: SMS after ten minutes, email next day, a call on day 3, then monthly.	Automation; call by Sales
6	Handover	One-page brief (answers, ad seen, all messages). Sales accepts or rejects within a business day, with a reason I review weekly.	Sales, with Marketing

The rules that stop it going wrong. - **Duplicates:** matched on mobile, email or company, merged, never restarted. Qubik clients go to their own accountant. - **Replies:** pause the automation; a person answers within two business hours. - **Opt-outs:** STOP or unsubscribe removes them everywhere immediately (the law allows five working days; ACMA). Every message identifies Qubik. - **Uncertain answers:** never auto-rejected. **Escalation:** complaints, privacy, price negotiation or automation failures go straight to a named person.

Who owns what. Marketing (me) owns ads, form, tiers, copy, nurture and weekly reporting. Automation (Qubik's specialist and IT) owns CRM connections, routing, messaging and consent records. Sales (Qubik) owns calls, accepting or rejecting leads, and closing the diagnostic and the build.

First email: > **Subject:** Your container costs, {FirstName} > > Hi {FirstName}, thanks for getting in touch. From your answers, {Company} is exactly who we built the Container Cost Check for. Next step is a 20-minute call with me about how your shipments get costed today, and whether the check is worth it for you. Grab a time: {link}, or just reply and I'll work around you. > > {Rep}, Qubik Accounting · {unsubscribe}

First SMS: > Hi {FirstName}, it's {Rep} from Qubik about your container costs enquiry. Book a quick call here: {link} Reply STOP to opt out

5. Economics and downside

These use the brief's rates, all applied to qualified leads, with A$73.5k as the midpoint implementation value:

	A$150 CPL	**A$225 CPL**
Leads (A$900 ÷ CPL)	6	4
Qualified (30%)	1.8	1.2
Attended (70% of qualified)	1.26	0.84
Diagnostics (50% of qualified)	0.9 = A$3,150	0.6 = A$2,100
Implementations (25% of qualified)	0.45 = A$33,075	0.3 = A$22,050
Gross attributed revenue	**A$36,225**	**A$24,150**

Across the A$57–90k range: A$28,800–43,650 and A$19,200–29,100. Crediting the diagnostic fee trims about A$1,600 and A$1,050.

Reading it honestly. A$900 buys four to six leads, so the real result is nothing or one sale; it tests the funnel rather than forecasting revenue. The rates are generous too: 7 in 10 attendees buying a diagnostic, and half of those going on to a build. And almost all the revenue is implementation, arriving two to four months later.

The plan I'd hold us to:

By	**Expect**	**If not**
A$450 spent	At least 2 leads, at least 1 qualified	Change the hook
A$900 spent	CPL at or under A$225, at least 30% qualified, at least 1 call booked	Work through the list below
Day 30	At least 1 diagnostic sold	Strengthen proof and offer

The main risk is lead quality, not lead cost. Each lead is worth about A$6,000 at the brief's rates, so even a A$600 CPL works if 30% qualify. But only about 3% of the people Meta can reach are real buyers. If the form fills with people who'll never buy, qualification drops to 10–15% and everything downstream shrinks.

What I'd change first: the filter. If qualification is low, I'd sharpen the callout ("for distributors who import by the container") and move revenue to the first question. Only after that, in order: the hook and video if CPL is high, response speed and the call offer if the right people aren't booking, and proof and founding terms if they book but don't buy.

6. Priorities, assumptions and AI

First 14 days: 1. **Check the ground before spending (days 1–5).** The audience check is done. Next: a Meta Ad Library scan for anyone already targeting distributors, five short conversations with distributors Qubik knows ⟦confirm⟧, and the automation specialist's sign-off that the check can be delivered in three weeks at a profit. 2. **Get launch-ready, then try to break the funnel (days 3–8).** Privacy policy, a Qubik page that looks alive, an accountant willing to be filmed, founding terms signed off, every rule in section 4 tested with dummy leads, and sales committed to the 15-minute call. 3. **Run the A$900 test (days 8–14 and on).** Daily checks, a proper read at A$450, and sales feedback on every lead.

Assumptions to validate: that late costing really hurts at this size; document access; willingness to pay A$3,500, then A$57–90k; sales capacity; my cost estimate and band split; pricing, consent and privacy compliance.

What I did, what AI did, and how I checked ⟦must be accurate; edit freely⟧.

- **My calls:** the segment came from my Cometlab experience, then testing. I rejected the AI's first two picks (trades, job-shop manufacturers), and sent drafts back for sounding machine-written and for chasing three problems at once. ⟦Add your own.⟧
- **Claude (Anthropic), via Claude Code:** summarised the brief, ran Python on ABS counts, made read-only Meta API calls to size the audience, searched sources, and drafted text I rewrote.
- **My checks:** spot-checked ABS figures in the source file, ⟦cross-checked Meta numbers in Ads Manager, if you do⟧, recalculated the economics by hand, opened every source and cut what I couldn't back, and checked ad length and ACCC/ACMA rules.